

Your Catering Co.

CATERING — PRICE LIST

SERVICE	TIME	PRICE
Drop-off catering	per person	\$30
Buffet dinner	per person	\$50
Plated dinner	per person	\$60
Corporate full-service	per person	\$110
Bar / beverage service add-on	per person	\$30

Per-person pricing by service style; staffing, rentals and bar service quoted separately. Tasting included on booked dates.

Made with mainstreettoolbox.com — free pricing tools for small business

The numbers behind this list

Every price on the front page is anchored to published 2026 US industry data — this page shows where each number comes from, and how wide the market band is. Where you land inside a band is your market position, your costs and your call.

Service	This list	2026 US band	Sources
Drop-off	\$30	\$20–40	WeddingWire
Buffet dinner	\$50	basic \$35–75	WeddingWire
Plated dinner	\$60	typical \$50–150; wedding avg \$40	WeddingWire
Corporate full-service	\$110	\$85–135	WeddingWire
Bar add-on	\$30	+\$25–40/person	WeddingWire

Bands are a synthesis across the named sources; individual publishers' own ranges sit above or below. Verified September 2026 · full database: mainstreettoolbox.com/benchmarks/service-pricing-2026/

How to work this list

Drop-off is a volume game

No staff, no rentals, thin margins, fast turns — it fills calendars between full-service bookings. Don't price it like staffed service.

Buffet math

Target 30% food cost: $\text{price} = \text{ingredient cost} \times 3.3$. If the menu costs more than that, cut SKUs before you cut margin.

Staffing prices separately

Servers add \$25–40 per person in real cost. Never bake it in — itemize it, or every quote looks high.

The bar is the profit center

Beverage service margins run 60–70%. Lead with it on every quote.

Contract anchors

50% deposit at booking, final headcount 7 days out, balance due day-of. Below ~50 guests, sell drop-off or refer out.

Free interactive calculators for this trade: **mainstreettoolbox.com** — type your numbers, get the band.

US pricing across the map — what the data shows

National bands hide huge regional spreads. These are the published data points for this trade — use them to place your city on the map.

Market / region	What the data shows	Source
National baseline	Average ~\$80 per person, typical \$62–123; plated wedding avg \$40 vs buffet \$27	WeddingWire
Los Angeles example	~\$70 per person traditional, ~\$85 with beverages	WeddingWire regional data
Florida example	Buffets \$35–75/guest; food-truck style \$20–40	WeddingWire regional data
Corporate full-service	\$85–135+ per person	WeddingWire

Regional points are as published by the named sources. Where your city isn't listed, the coastal/metro premium pattern is the planning heuristic — then validate locally (next page).

How to judge YOUR local market — the five-step method

1. **Start from the national band** — pages 1–2 of this kit.
2. **Apply the regional adjustment** — coastal metros +20–50% across our research; small towns slightly under. Your state's cost-of-living index is a reasonable proxy.
3. **Compute your cost floor** — (your loaded hours + materials/supplies) for the job. No quote below the floor, ever. It's the line between a business and a hobby.
4. **Validate locally** — three published local prices (Angi/HomeGuide zip-level or competitor pages) tell you where the market actually clears.
5. **Set your band and review quarterly** — booked out two weeks straight? Move up. Empty for a month? Your floor is above your market.

Worked example — Buffet dinner for 80 guests, corporate event, Atlanta GA

Step 1. National: buffet \$27 avg; basic buffets \$35–75 → pick \$48/pp mid-band.

Step 2. Food cost: $\$16/\text{pp} \times 80 = \$1,280$ ingredients at 33% food cost.

Step 3. Staffing: $4 \text{ servers} \times 6 \text{ hrs} \times \$25 = \$600$; rentals \$400.

Step 4. Price: $\$48 \times 80 = \$3,840$ + staffing/rentals itemized → ~35% margin after all-in. Bar add-on at \$30/pp is your 60%+ margin sweetener.

Catering prices are per-person, but the margin is per-line-item. Itemize everything.

Strategy — the five plays that move the number

The service-style ladder

Drop-off → buffet → plated → full-service. Each rung adds staffing and rentals — price each rung separately and let clients climb.

Buffet math

30% food cost target: menu price = ingredient cost $\times$ 3.3. When the menu drifts expensive, cut SKUs — never cut the multiplier.

Staffing itemized, always

\$25–40/pp of real cost baked into a per-person price makes every quote look high. Line it, explain it, own it.

The bar is the profit center

Beverage service runs 60–70% margin. Lead every quote with it; it's the difference between a job and a business.

Contract anchors

50% deposit at booking, final headcount 7 days out, balance due day-of. Below ~50 guests, sell drop-off or refer out — plated service for 30 loses money at any price.

Free interactive calculators for this trade: **mainstreettoolbox.com** — every rule on this page, computed for your numbers.